



Software Assurance Program Guide



What is this guide?

This program guide provides an in-depth overview of Software Assurance and the benefits available through Software Assurance. It's designed to be an ongoing resource throughout the lifecycle of your Software Assurance commitments with Microsoft Commercial Licensing Agreements.

Who is this guide intended for?

- Customers who are new to Microsoft Commercial Licensing and want to learn more about the value of Software Assurance for their organization.
- Customers who want to learn more about the broad set of benefits available through Software Assurance.
- Customers who have Software Assurance and have questions about using or activating benefits.





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Software Assurance

Innovation and change characterize technology—today, perhaps more than ever. Organizations need to respond with agility and speed to deliver and manage the technology users demand, on the devices they chose, wherever they need to work.

Software Assurance supports your ongoing success by helping you take full advantage of your investments in IT. A comprehensive program that includes a unique set of technologies, services, and rights to help deploy, manage, and use Microsoft products efficiently, Software Assurance helps keep you up to date and ready to respond quickly to challenges and opportunities.



Enhancing licensing value



Software Assurance helps unlock the full potential of your investments in Microsoft technologies.

- Reduce software and services costs with rights to new software releases and cost-efficient upgrades.
- Improve operational efficiency through access to unique technologies and licensing rights.
- Contribute to lower infrastructure costs with license mobility rights to assign specific server licenses to a cloud-hosting partner.
- Streamline deployments with onsite consulting to help plan for deployment of new on-premises IT initiatives.
- Impact overall user productivity with instructor-led technical training.

Improving business agility



Software Assurance provides a broad range of benefits that help save time and improve business agility.

- Broaden the value of server licenses through extended use on-premises and in the cloud.
- Maintain an available and responsive IT infrastructure with around-the-clock support.
- Manage virtual desktops from a variety of devices and locations with extended license rights.
- Access enhanced use rights for disaster recovery and availability.
- Reduce time spent integrating, managing, and troubleshooting devices with unique optimization tools and services.
- Enable work-from-home and on-the-road scenarios with unique technologies available only to Software Assurance customers.

How to get Software Assurance

[Microsoft Commercial Licensing](#) is the most cost-effective, flexible, and manageable way to acquire Microsoft software and cloud services. [Software Assurance](#) is only available through Commercial Licensing and is purchased when you buy or renew a Commercial Licensing agreement. It's included with some agreements and is an optional purchase with others. Your available benefits are determined by the types of products and the quantity you purchase.

Find a [Microsoft Partner](#) to help you get started.

Commercial Licensing programs are tailored to the needs of different types and sizes of organizations.

Enterprise Agreement

includes Software Assurance and offers the best value if you have 500 or more users or devices and want a manageable Commercial Licensing program that gives you the flexibility to buy cloud services and software licenses under one agreement.

Microsoft Products and Services Agreement

is for transactional purchases of Microsoft online services and software, with Software Assurance as an optional purchase. Suited for organizations with 250 or more users, the Microsoft Products and Services Agreement is the best option for buying what you need, when you need it.

Open Value

is an affordable way for small to midsize organizations with at least five devices or users to manage and use Microsoft licensed products under a single licensing agreement. Includes Software Assurance and is also available as a subscription (Open Value Subscription) if you want to subscribe to rather than acquire Microsoft product licenses.

Open License

is a good choice if you prefer a pay-as-you-go model and have a minimum initial purchase of five software licenses. Software Assurance is an optional purchase with Open License.

Select Plus

is designed for midsize and large organizations with 250 or more devices with multiple affiliates, and Software Assurance is an optional purchase. Note that new Select Plus commercial agreements are no longer sold but it is available to government and academic customers.

Campus and School Agreement

is designed for qualified academic customers with a minimum 1,000 equivalent employees or students and includes Software Assurance.

Commercial Licensing programs for government

are available for all sizes of eligible organizations. Software Assurance is included with some Commercial Licensing agreements for government and is available as an optional purchase with others.



Available benefits

Software Assurance includes a unique set of technologies, services, and rights to help you deploy, manage, and use Microsoft products.

By benefit

(page 1 of 2)

By product

Deploy and manage

New Version Rights

Upgrade each Microsoft product license that's covered by active Software Assurance to the most recent version for no additional cost.

License Mobility Through Software Assurance

Allows you to deploy certain server applications on-premises or in the cloud in an authorized hosting partner's datacenter, without having to buy additional licenses.

Enterprise Source Licensing Program

Provides access to Microsoft Windows source code for internal development and support.

Windows Virtual Desktop Access Rights

Enable users to access virtual instances of Windows 10 (or previous operating system versions) in a variety of use scenarios.

Windows To Go Use Rights

Provides a fully manageable corporate desktop running Windows 10 Enterprise edition on a bootable USB stick that can be run on any licensed device or by any licensed user.

Servers Self Hosted Applications

The Self Hosting benefit allows customers with Software Assurance to provide their own software as a hosted service using a combination of Microsoft software and their own software to create a unified solution ("Unified Solution"), subject to the terms outlined in the Microsoft Product Terms.

Office Online Services and Office Online Server (OOS)

Provides browser-based versions of Word, PowerPoint, Excel, and OneNote from on-premises environments.

Office Roaming Use Rights

Allows users to remotely access Office, Project, or Visio on their virtual desktops from third-party devices.

Windows 10 Enterprise per User Add-on

The optional Windows 10 Enterprise per User Add-on provides Windows Software Assurance per User rights for a primary user with a primary device that's licensed for Windows Enterprise, or Windows VDA per User rights for a primary user with a primary device that's licensed with Windows VDA.

Planning Services

With Planning Services, qualified partners or Microsoft Consulting Services can help you plan your deployment.

Retiring in January 2022

Microsoft Desktop Optimization Pack (MDOP)

Provides a suite of innovative technologies including virtualization, policy control, and diagnostics and recovery tools.

Overview	How to get	Benefits	Scenarios	How to use	FAQ	Resources
Available benefits Software Assurance includes a unique set of technologies, services, and rights to help you deploy, manage, and use Microsoft products.						
	By benefit (page 2 of 2) By product					
Training	Support			Specialized		
Home Use Program Lets employees purchase the latest version of Microsoft Office 365 to use at home for a reduced price.	Problem Resolution Support Provides around-the-clock phone support for business-critical issues or business hours phone support for non-critical. Unlimited email support can be used for non-critical problems.		Servers Disaster Recovery Rights Provides licensing for backup servers dedicated to disaster recovery. Permits quarterly patching and testing, and ongoing virtual machine replication from production servers to backup/disaster recovery servers.		Step-up Licensing Allows you to migrate your software from a lower to higher level edition at a low cost. You won't pay full cost of each edition, just the pricing difference.	
Training Vouchers Provides in-depth technical classroom training for IT professionals and developers. Retiring in January 2022	Microsoft Dynamics CustomerSource Microsoft Dynamics CustomerSource is an online portal that includes a broad set of product and service support resources for Dynamics customers with Software Assurance coverage.		Fail over Rights Allows a passive-fail-over instance (i.e., non-production, but "warm" instance) run in OSEs on the licensed Server or another server on another server in anticipation of a fail-over event.		Spread Payments Allows you to spread the costs of your License and Software Assurance purchase across three equal, annual sums versus one up-front payment.	

Overview

How to get

Benefits

Scenarios

How to use

FAQ

Resources

Core benefits by product

Software Assurance spans a broad range of Microsoft software and services products, including the Windows operating system, Microsoft Office, Exchange, System Center, SQL Server, and many others. Your Commercial Licensing purchases determine which benefits apply.

By benefit

By product

Office	Windows	Server and tools
New Version Rights	Enterprise Source Licensing Program	Azure Hybrid Benefit
Office 365 Home Use Program	Microsoft Desktop Optimization Pack (MDOP)	Exchange Online Voicemail
Office Online Services and Office Online Server	New Version Rights	License Mobility through Software Assurance
Office Roaming Use Rights	Spread Payments	New Version Rights
Problem Resolution Support	Windows 10 Enterprise per User Add-on availability	Problem Resolution Support
Spread Payments	Windows Roaming Use Rights	Servers-Disaster Recovery rights
Step-up Licensing Availability	Windows To Go Use Rights	Fail-over Rights
Planning Services (to be fully retired January 2022)	Windows Virtual Desktop Access (VDA) Rights	Spread Payments
Technical Training (to be fully retired January 2022)	Technical Training (to be fully retired January 2022)	Step-up Licensing Availability
		Planning Services (to be fully retired January 2022)
		Technical Training (to be fully retired January 2022)

Software Assurance benefits are used in a variety of ways across organizations and industries. When combined with the technologies you support every day, the wide-ranging set of benefits can help your organization take full advantage of your Microsoft investments. Here are just some examples of the ways you can get the most from your Software Assurance benefits.

Plan, use, and support—smarter

IT investments are at the core of your organization; they help keep it efficient, agile, and responsive to customer demands. To maximize their contribution to your success, those investments must be smartly deployed, managed, and operated.

Software Assurance [Planning Services](#)* can help with that. Expert consultants help you plan a custom deployment tailored to your organization and to the requirements of your customers. Then to complement your plan, IT staff can use [Training Vouchers](#)* at no additional cost for in-depth classroom training to help enhance current skills and master new technologies.

Finally, for added peace of mind, [Problem Resolution Support](#) provides around-the-clock web and phone support to help keep your updated IT environment efficient and available.

*Planning Services and Training Vouchers are being retired and are available to use until January 2022.



A photograph of two men in a server room. One man is standing and looking at a laptop screen, while the other is leaning over him, also looking at the screen. They are in a room with rows of server racks.

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On-premises, off-premises, in the cloud—on plan

Organizations around the world are excited about the potential they see in cloud computing. You may already be considering the benefits of using outsourced or cloud-based services for one or more of your server-based applications. Whether off-premises or in your own environment, Software Assurance helps you prepare for cloud migrations with a powerful combination of consultancy and innovative server licensing opportunities.

Lower-cost off-premises deployments can prove easier to scale and take less effort to manage. [License Mobility through Software Assurance](#) helps you retain the value of your existing server license investments by extending their use to the cloud when you assign eligible server licenses to an authorized hosting partner—no need to buy additional licenses.

If you decide to take advantage of opportunities offered by the cloud, [Planning Services](#)* partners help you build a deployment, upgrade, or migration plan tailored for your organization. With flexible offerings, Planning Services help extend your internal expertise by incorporating best practices for deploying an array of Microsoft solutions on-premises, in the cloud, or in hybrid environments.

With the [Azure Hybrid Benefit](#) you can bring Windows Server and SQL Server on-premises licenses with Software Assurance to Azure Migrate your workloads to Azure.

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A boost for efficiency and productivity

You've given your employees the technology they need; now you're looking to help them take full advantage of those tools to be as effective as they can.

Productive employees are a key ingredient in an agile business. When they use the same software at home and at work, they can gain skills more quickly and make a greater contribution. The [Home Use Program \(HUP\)](#) benefit offers your employees a way to buy the latest version of Microsoft Office 365 subscription for their use at home for a reduced price.

In addition, your [New Version Rights](#) benefit helps ensure that your employees are always using the latest versions of the software they need.

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Optimize and enhance work styles

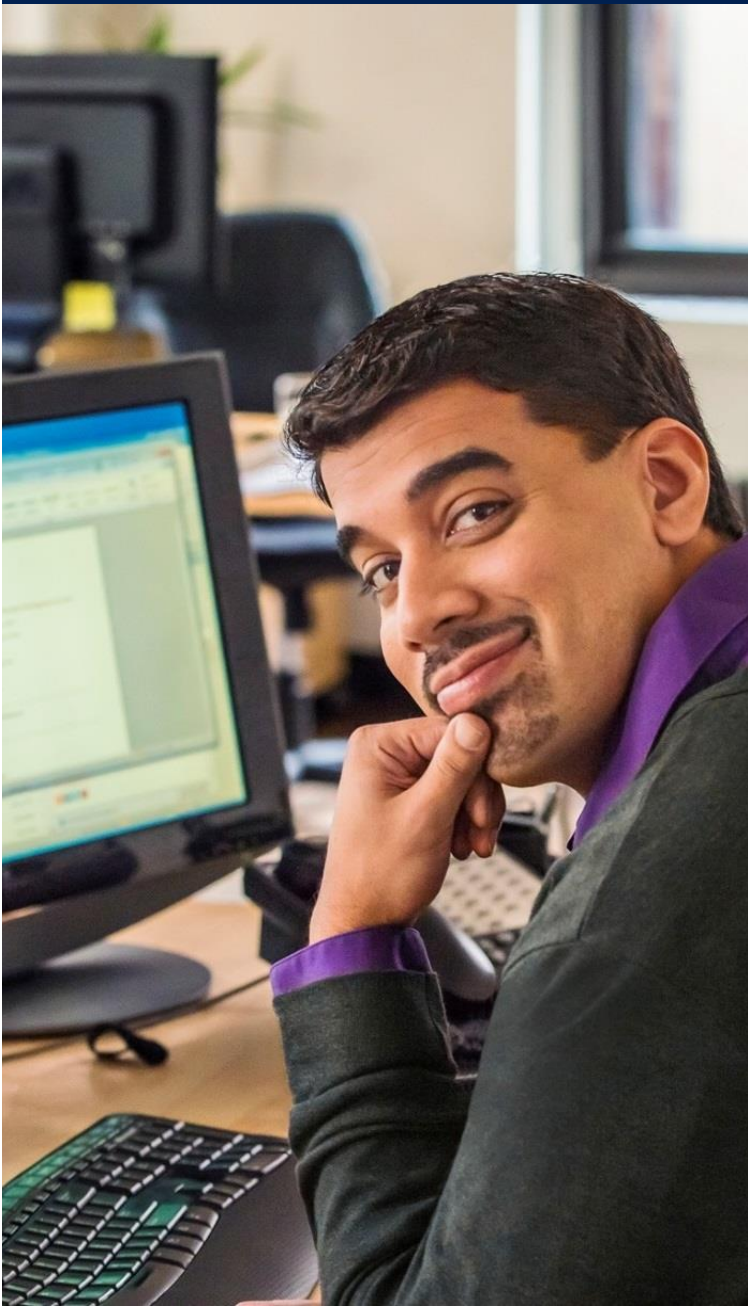
Your company is growing quickly, and you have a diverse mix of existing employees, new employees, temporary staff, and mobile workers. Employees need to use a variety of company-owned and personal devices in order to work effectively in the office and on the road.

Your Software Assurance [Windows To Go Use Rights](#) help your employees work where they choose and on a broad range of licensed devices, using your preconfigured Windows image that can be loaded on-the-fly from a USB storage device.

In addition, [Office Roaming Use Rights](#) allow remote access to Microsoft Office via a virtual environment from a variety of public and private devices—with no additional licenses to buy, and without installing any additional software.

For each of your employees in their various roles, you can personalize their experience, simplify application deployment, and improve application compatibility with the [Microsoft Desktop Optimization Pack \(MDOP\)](#). MDOP is a suite of technologies that help manage, secure, and monitor your devices, while simplifying and accelerating the deployment of key Windows features. You get greater control of the software your employees are using, less downtime, and support that is more streamlined.





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Power-up your IT investments

Microsoft Commercial Licensing is the most cost-effective, flexible, and manageable way to acquire Microsoft products and services. Commercial Licensing customers can enhance their IT investments further with Software Assurance. Benefits apply across a broad range of licensing agreements, some benefits being unique to Software Assurance customers; you get the tools and training you need to do more with the IT investments you make and the investments you've already made.

Among the many ways that Software Assurance helps you spend less and do more with your IT investments, [Planning Services](#)* provide on-site consultants to collaborate with your IT staff and help you evaluate how you can efficiently deploy a range of Microsoft solutions. Flexible licensing rights and use options help you empower your office and mobile workers on a broad range of devices and reduce support costs. In addition, your employees can access [technical training](#)* without affecting your training budget.

Along with technical cost-savers, you also get help with budgeting. The Software Assurance [Spread Payments](#) benefit works with your budget and helps lower your initial licensing costs. Instead of one up-front payment, you spread the costs of your Commercial Licensing and Software Assurance purchase across three equal, annual sums, helping you forecast your technology budget up to three years in advance.

*Planning Services and Training Vouchers are being retired and are available to use until January 2022.

How to start using your benefits

Get to know what benefits your organization is entitled to through your Commercial Licensing agreement, and develop an action plan to activate and use them.



Activating Software Assurance benefits

Your Software Assurance benefits are activated in the Volume Licensing Service Center (VLSC). Before you can activate your Software Assurance benefits in VLSC, your organization needs to provide you with Software Assurance Manager permissions. Once signed-in, you'll find a complete list of your available Software Assurance benefits. Getting started and using each individual benefit may differ slightly, but the processes are similar for most.

Review the [VLSC Software Assurance Guide](#) (PDF, 923 KB) for steps to activate, download, and use your benefits.

Sign in to the [VLSC](#).

Microsoft Products and Services Agreement (MPSA)

If your organization has a Microsoft Products and Services Agreement (MPSA), go to the Microsoft Business Center to access and start using your benefits. Your Software Assurance benefits are ready to view and use once you sign in to the Microsoft Business Center. When you're signed in, you'll find instructions to get started with each benefit, links to more detailed information about each one, and sample communications to send to your users.

Sign in to [Microsoft Business Center](#).

Managing your Software Assurance benefit portfolio

A consideration when choosing whether to have one or more individuals manage your organization's Software Assurance benefits is the size of your organization and the scope of benefits that are available to you. A large enterprise that will access multiple benefits across multiple organizations may find decentralized benefits management most effective. A small or midsize organization may find it more efficient to centralize benefits management with one individual or department.

Benefit manager suggestions with a sampling of benefits



IT managers

Deployment resources and tools, for example Planning Services*, Microsoft Desktop Optimization Pack (MDOP), License Mobility through Software Assurance

New products and unique license rights, for example New Version Rights, Windows Virtual Desktop Access Rights

Deployment resources and tools, for example Planning Services*, Microsoft Desktop Optimization Pack (MDOP), License Mobility through Software Assurance

Technical training and learning resources, for example Training Vouchers*, Home Use Program

Support, for example 24x7 Problem Resolution Support, Back-up for Disaster Recovery



HR and training managers

Home Use Program (HUP) additional resources are available to promote HUP to your employees at <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/Licensing/licensing-programs/software-assurance-by-benefits?activetab=software-assurance-by-benefits-tab:primaryr4>

Technical training for IT pros and developers accessed through Training Vouchers.*

Frequently Asked Questions

What is Software Assurance, and why do I need it?

Software Assurance is a comprehensive Commercial Licensing program that includes a unique set of technologies, services, and rights to help you deploy, manage, and use your Microsoft products more efficiently. Using Software Assurance benefits can help you take full advantage of your investments in IT.

How do I get Software Assurance?

Software Assurance is included with some [Commercial Licensing programs](#) and is an optional purchase with others. You can purchase Software Assurance through [Microsoft partners](#) via your Commercial Licensing agreement.

What Software Assurance benefits are included in my Commercial Licensing agreement?

Your available benefits are determined by your Commercial Licensing agreement, the types of products, and the quantity you purchase. Download the [Software Assurance Benefits Chart](#) (PDF, 2.2 MB) from the [Software Assurance](#) website for an overview of each benefit, and descriptions showing which benefits apply to each type of Commercial Licensing agreement.

Where can I learn more about individual Software Assurance benefits?

Visit [Software Assurance Overview](#) to find more details and resources for each benefit.

How do I start using my Software Assurance benefits?

Your Software Assurance benefits are activated in the [Volume Licensing Service Center \(VLSC\)](#), where you'll find a complete list of your available Software Assurance benefits. Getting started and using each individual benefit may differ slightly, but the processes are similar for most. Review the [VLSC Software Assurance Guide](#) (PDF, 785 KB) for steps to activate, download, and use your benefits. Sign in to [VLSC](#).

Microsoft Products and Services Agreement (MPSA) customers

If your organization has a Microsoft Products and Services Agreement (MPSA), go to the Microsoft Business Center to access and start using your benefits. Once signed in, you'll find instructions to get started with each benefit, links to more detailed information about each one, and sample communications to send to your users. Sign in to [Microsoft Business Center](#).



Resources

Buying or renewing Software Assurance

Software Assurance is purchased through Microsoft resellers via Commercial Licensing agreements <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/licensing/licensing-programs/licensing-programs>

Find a Microsoft reseller www.microsoft.com/en-US/solution-providers/search

Online tools to activate and manage Software Assurance benefits

Microsoft Volume Licensing Service Center (VLSC) www.microsoft.com/Licensing/servicecenter/default.aspx

Steps to activate, download, and use benefits [VLSC Software Assurance Guide](#) (PDF, 923 KB)

MPSA customers go to the Microsoft Business Center <https://businessaccount.microsoft.com/customer>

Benefit resources

Find a qualified Planning Services Partner <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/solution-providers>

Home Use Program (HUP) order site <https://www.microsoft.com/licensing/licensing-programs/software-assurance-by-benefits>

Training Vouchers overview www.microsoft.com/learning/software-assurance-benefits.aspx

Microsoft Desktop Optimization Pack (MDOP) <https://docs.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-desktop-optimization-pack/>

Worldwide

Find Microsoft Commercial Licensing information for specific countries and regions www.microsoft.com/en-us/licensing/worldwide

Where to learn more

- Software Assurance <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/licensing/licensing-programs/software-assurance-default>
- Microsoft Worldwide Commercial Licensing www.microsoft.com/licensing/
- Microsoft Volume Licensing Service Center <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/licensing/existing-customer/vlsc-training-and-resources>
- Payment Solutions <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/licensing/how-to-buy/financing>



